



The Best Places to Eat Asam Laksa

Asam Laksa Stall inexpensive

Locals will tell you that this humble stand, west of downtown Georgetown near the foot of Penang Hill, serves the best *asam laksa* in Penang – in which case, it's probably the best *asam laksa* available anywhere. The local family running the show follows the classic recipe and, as everything is laid out at the front of the stand, you can follow the whole process, from chopping and slicing the ingredients through to spooning out the seasoned stock into the bowls of noodles and adding the garnishes. It's all ridiculously cheap but, as portions are generous, you won't need a second bowl. After your meal, be sure to visit the nearby Kek Lok Si, an absurd, pagoda-like temple on an octagonal base dating to 1893, full of brightly painted moldings and Buddhist statuary. On the hill behind the market is a spectacular, 100-foot- (30-m-) high bronze statue of Guanyin, the Chinese goddess of mercy, only completed in 2003.

Ayer Itam market, Jalan Ayer Itam; open noon–8 PM daily

Also in Penang

While the Asam Laksa Stall (*above*) might have a monopoly on the tastiest *asam laksa*, the **Pesiaran Gurney Night Hawker Centre**, around 1½ miles (3 km) west of central Georgetown – or rather the adjacent waterfront promenade – is definitely the most atmospheric place to eat it. Sit out here with sociable crowds and enjoy the dusk and fresh air, with excellent *laksa* served up fresh at dozens of street stands – just aim for the busiest one.

Also in Malaysia

In Malaysia's capital, Kuala Lumpur, **Mark's Asam Laksa** in the Weld shopping center (+60 2487 0050; *inexpensive*) is a central branch of a cheerful restaurant chain serving good-quality *asam laksa* in comfortable, if not exciting, surroundings; try their *hong dou sha* (sweet red bean soup) as an unusual dessert.

Around the World

For a different take on what *laksa* is all about, head to East Coast Road in Singapore, where **328 Katong Laksa** (+65 9732 8163; *inexpensive*) – along with hundreds of other restaurants across the city – serves the richer version with shrimp, coconut milk, and a heavier, more curry-oriented flavor. Katong's menu stretches to little but *laksa*, but their *otak-otak* (spiced, minced fish steamed in banana-leaf packets) makes a good side dish.